born out of her own experience of bringing up her child. The charitable trust celebrates the artistic talents of specially-abled young adults, and curates and displays their painting, sculpture, films and photographs. The aim of TAS is to pave the way for the inclusion of talented, and variously challenged, youngsters in the mainstream art world.

But showcasing their work meant these youngsters needed training in a conducive environment to upgrade their skills. Thus, TAS began online workshops. Besides, it has a tie-up with the Film and Television Institute of India (FTII) in Pune for a course in short filmmaking. There's an arrangement with the National Gallery of Modern Art (NGMA) to host painting or clay modelling workshops. "We displayed art made by these young adults for the first time in a commercial gallery four years back and sold 70 per cent of it," says Gupta. TAS has held exhibitions in the Kiran Nadar Museum of Art in New Delhi and the NGMA in Delhi, Mumbai and Bengaluru. While TAS works with around 50 youngsters in its workshops, it reaches out to about 1,500 families across India when exhibitions are held via parent support groups in 20 cities.

HAPPINESS MANTRA

"The tears in the eyes of a mom as her son is felicitated... as a young filmmaker are those of pure joy"

SHALINI GUPTA, Founder, The Art Sanctuary

At the art session, Sania Khimji wears a tiara she recently won at a beauty pageant to commemorate International Disability Month, along with runner-up Dinal Jain, who is also a swimming champ. Then, there's Sai Shashank Sivaramakrishnan, whose glazed pottery work occupies pride of place alongside the paintings on display. "I feel he's at total peace when he is holding wet clay," says his mother Viji.

"When our children were born, the world told us to expect only tears and therapy.... But look at the amount of joy around us," marvels Gupta. After TAS held its first art exhibition in 2019, there was a marked lift in the mood of some of the young artists, and their dosage of medicines like anti-depressants came down. "They might take four years for a course that you and I would finish in four months. But who is in a rush?" Truly, it's the joy of learning that counts. ■

INDIA TODAY RPG Happiness Quest

A Different High

Happiness delivery: Once drug addicts themselves, the couple now runs a drug rehabilitation centre in Guwahati

By **KAUSHIK DEKA**

SHRISHTI WELLNESS HOME
FOUNDED: 2020
Guwahati

Amrit Baishya was a brilliant student at the Kendriya Vidyalaya he studied in at Noonmati in Guwahati. The only son in a middle-class family, he was highly pampered, every wish of his fulfilled as soon as he uttered it. That his father ran a successful travel agency business and mother worked as a government school teacher also helped. Being among the toppers in every class, he also gave his parents no reason to complain. Nothing seemed off limits, even drinking with senior school students when he was in Class 10. When his parents did intervene, he would flaunt his marksheet at them.

He was in Class 11 in 2010 when Amrit decided it was time to graduate to something bigger. He first experimented with drugs out of the Rs 500 he had taken from his parents to buy a book. Experimentation soon gave way to addiction, and the high scores to a downhill journey away from classrooms and in the dark alleys of Guwahati. Several temporary stints at rehabilitation centres followed, to no avail. Eventually, tired of his constant demand for money, stealing and uncontrollable aggression, Amrit's parents threw him out of their house on June 24, 2017.

It was something that Amrit had not expected. He had taken the support system for granted. With that withdrawn, he either had to take control of his life or hurtle towards unimaginable disaster. Fortunately, he chose to give life another chance and reached out to a friend he had met at a rehab centre. A reformed soul himself, the friend called him to Margherita, a town 500 km east of Guwahati. In the next 10 days, a group of former addicts instilled a sense of purpose in Amrit's mind, and he vowed never to touch drugs again. He returned to Guwahati and started doing errands at var-